

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 14

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: Two estranged adult brothers meet at their father’s grave for the first time in nearly a decade.

1

I arrived a quarter of an hour early, which was, I suppose, my way of pretending that I had not been thinking about the meeting for weeks. The cemetery had been recently mown, and the cut grass clung to my shoes in damp green crescents. Our father’s headstone stood near the wall, modest, pale, exactly as the undertaker had described it on the telephone eight years ago. I had not been back since the burial. I told myself that this was because of the distance, and that the distance was not, in any meaningful sense, my fault.

2

Daniel came up the path at three minutes past the hour. I recognised him before I saw his face — the slight stoop, the careful, unhurried walk that had always made our mother shake her head and call him **the old man of the family**, though he was the younger by two years. He had grown a beard. The beard had grey in it. We shook hands. The handshake lasted perhaps half a second longer than was necessary, which, between us, counted as an embrace.

3

“You found it all right, then,” I said.

“I found it.”

“The path’s longer than I remembered.”

“It is.”

We stood side by side and looked at the stone, which gave us, mercifully, something to look at that was not each other. A robin landed on the wall behind the grave, considered us with one black bead of an eye, and flew off again. Somewhere far off, a lawnmower started, then stopped. I could not think of a single sentence that did not feel either too small or too large for the moment.

4

“You came down from York?” I asked, eventually.

“Leeds, now. Two years.”

“Ah.”

He did not ask where I had come from. He knew, presumably, or had decided not to. The old quarrel — the one about the house, about what our father had meant in the will, about which of us had visited him in his last six months and which had not — sat between us as plainly as the headstone. I had rehearsed, on the train, several careful speeches about it. None of them now seemed worth the trouble of beginning.

5

“I don’t want to do it today,” Daniel said, without looking at me.

“No.”

“I just thought —”

“No,” I said again. “Not today.”

He nodded once. We let the quarrel lie where it was, like an animal we had agreed, for the moment, not to wake. I felt, briefly and surprisingly, a kind of tired gratitude towards him for naming the thing aloud, since I had not been brave enough to.

6

After a while he said, “Do you remember the bicycle?”

I did remember the bicycle. Our father had bought it second-hand the summer Daniel turned nine, painted it a violent municipal red in the back garden, and presented it to him on the morning of his birthday with the solemnity of a man knighting a son. Daniel had ridden it into a hedge within the hour. Our father, instead of being cross, had laughed until he had to sit down on the back step, and the laughter had set us all off, even our mother, who normally considered laughter on a Sunday to be slightly disreputable.

7

“I’d forgotten the hedge,” I said.

“I haven’t. I’ve still got a scar.” He pulled back the cuff of his coat half an inch, showed me a thin pale line on the inside of his wrist, and put the cuff back. We both smiled at the same time. It was not a large smile, and it did not, I think, settle anything between us. But it was the first thing in eight years that had passed from his face to mine without anything sharp attached to it.

8

We stayed another twenty minutes. We did not talk about the will, or about our mother, who was in a home in Devon and was beginning, the doctors said, to forget our names. When it was time to go, Daniel said he would write. I said I would, too. Neither of us, I suspect, fully believed the other; but as I walked back down the path, with the cut grass still clinging to my shoes, I found I was no longer pretending I had not been thinking about him for weeks. I was thinking about him quite openly, and the thought, for once, did not hurt.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he arrived early as “my way of pretending that I had not been thinking about the meeting for weeks.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about his state of mind before the meeting. [2]

2. The narrator writes that he had not returned to the grave since the burial, blaming “the distance, and that the distance was not, in any meaningful sense, my fault.” What does this admission suggest about his real feelings? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes the handshake with his brother as lasting “half a second longer than was necessary, which, between us, counted as an embrace.” Explain what this phrase suggests about the relationship between the two brothers. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show how awkward the conversation was at first. [2]

5. The narrator says the headstone “gave us, mercifully, something to look at that was not each other.” What does the word **mercifully** suggest about how the brothers were feeling? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes the old quarrel as sitting between them “as plainly as the headstone.” What is the **effect** of this comparison? [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The brothers compare the quarrel to “an animal we had agreed, for the moment, not to wake.” Explain how this image describes their decision. [2]

8. The narrator feels “a kind of tired gratitude” towards Daniel. Explain, in your own words, why he feels grateful. [2]

From Paragraph 6

9. The father presented the bicycle “with the solemnity of a man knighting a son.” What does this comparison suggest about the father? [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator writes that the smile “did not, I think, settle anything between us.” Why, then, does he describe it as significant? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the passage? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the rise of “quiet quitting” and what it reveals about modern work.

1

In the summer of 2022, a short video by an American engineer named Zaid Khan briefly held the attention of the internet. In it, he described a quiet decision he had made about his job: he would continue to perform his duties to a competent standard, but he would no longer go beyond them. He would not answer messages at night. He would not volunteer for projects that fell outside his role. He gave the practice a name — **quiet quitting** — and within weeks the phrase had been argued over in newspaper columns, management seminars and, with rather more energy, in family kitchens around the world. The label was new. The thing it described was not.

2

Quiet quitting, in its plainest definition, is the practice of doing only what one’s job description requires. The “quitting” is metaphorical; the worker remains employed and continues to draw a salary. What is being abandoned is not the post but a particular cultural contract — the unspoken expectation, common in many white-collar workplaces of the past two decades, that an employee will routinely give the firm an hour or two beyond the contracted day, will answer a message that arrives at nine in the evening, and will treat such generosity as a normal cost of being taken seriously.

3

The phenomenon is, unsurprisingly, generational, though not exclusively so. Surveys conducted in 2023 by Gallup found that workers under the age of thirty-five reported the lowest levels of “engagement” with their employers in more than a decade, and that the steepest decline had taken place since the start of the pandemic. The reasons are economic as much as cultural. Wages in many sectors have not kept pace with the cost of housing; the promotion ladders that once justified extra hours have, in many companies, been quietly retracted; and the pandemic itself reminded a generation of workers that the workplace they had been pouring themselves into could, in the space of a fortnight, be folded up and sent home.

4

Employers have responded with a curious mixture of indignation and panic. A handful of senior executives, interviewed in the trade press, have called quiet quitters “lazy”, “entitled” or worse; one prominent banker described the practice as “an insult to the firms that employ them”. Other companies have taken a quieter, harder line. Internal monitoring software — the kind that counts keystrokes, tracks active hours, and pings managers if a mouse goes still for more than a few minutes — has spread rapidly across remote and hybrid workplaces. The signal sent by such measures, intended or not, is that trust is no longer the default; effort is to be measured, not assumed.

5

Yet not every employer has reached for the surveillance dashboard. Others have begun, however slowly, to ask a different question: what if the problem is not that workers are doing less, but that the firm has been quietly asking for more without admitting it? A 2023 review in the **Harvard Business Review** argued that “quiet quitting” was often a polite description of an older phenomenon — burnout — and that the most effective response was not punishment but renegotiation: clearer job descriptions, protected time off, and managers willing to model, rather than merely tolerate, a sensible end to the working day.

6

Whether quiet quitting is, in the end, a healthy correction or a worrying symptom depends in large part on where one stands. Its defenders argue that it is no more than boundary-setting of the sort that older generations were too anxious, or too grateful, to attempt. To do one’s job well, and then to go home and

live, is hardly a moral failing. Its critics counter that a workforce which refuses, on principle, to go a step further than the contract is a workforce that has stopped believing in the work itself — and that this, in the long run, is bad for workers as well as employers, because meaning at work, for most people, comes precisely from the small acts of going beyond.

7

What seems likeliest is that the phrase will fade — labels of this kind always do — but the conversation will not. A generation has, perhaps for the first time in a long while, looked steadily at the terms on which it has been asked to work and decided, in many cases, that those terms need rewriting. The firms that listen will adjust their expectations, their pay, and the small, accumulating insults of a working day until they earn the loyalty they used to assume. The firms that do not will, in time, discover that the quietest form of quitting is, in fact, the loudest.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the **label** of quiet quitting was new but “the thing it described was not.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, why is the word **quitting** described as “metaphorical”? Answer in your own words. [2]

14. The writer refers to “the unspoken expectation” found in many white-collar workplaces. Give **two** examples from Paragraph 2 of what this expectation involves. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says the phenomenon is “generational, though not exclusively so.” Explain what this phrase tells us about who quiet quitting affects. [2]

16. From Paragraph 3, give **two** economic reasons why younger workers are disengaging from their employers. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. Why does the writer place the words **lazy** and **entitled** in inverted commas? [1]

18. The writer says that monitoring software signals that “trust is no longer the default; effort is to be measured, not assumed.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about how some employers now view their staff. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer suggests that quiet quitting may be “a polite description of an older phenomenon — burnout.” What is the writer’s **attitude** towards employers who reach for surveillance rather than renegotiation? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer presents two opposing views about quiet quitting. Using your own words, give **one** point made by its **defenders** and **one** point made by its **critics**. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by claiming that “the quietest form of quitting is, in fact, the loudest.” Explain what is **effective** about this contrast. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the reasons why workers, especially younger ones, are practising quiet quitting** and **the different ways employers have responded**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Many workers, particularly younger ones, are quietly quitting because ...

— END OF PAPER —